

FretGarden Pedagogical Constitution

PEDAGOGICAL STANDARD

Chapter 6 - Mastery, Readiness, and Progression	Version 1.0
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This document forms part of the FretGarden Pedagogical Constitution. Normative terms are used according to the Foundation.

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Chapter 6 - Mastery, Readiness, and Progression

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1. Purpose

This chapter defines how FretGarden determines whether a learner has developed a capability sufficiently to rely on it, whether the learner is ready for dependent work, and how progression through the educational system may occur without confusing exposure, completion, temporary performance, or accumulated activity with learning.

Mastery, readiness, and progression are related but distinct judgments.

Mastery concerns the strength and scope of a demonstrated capability. Readiness concerns whether the learner possesses enough of the required prerequisites to undertake a particular next demand productively. Progression concerns the educational decision to introduce, unlock, recommend, defer, revisit, or require material based on readiness, goals, and the structure of the curriculum.

A learner may be ready to begin a new topic without having comprehensively mastered every related prerequisite. A learner may have mastered a narrowly defined capability without being ready for a broader integrated task. A learner may complete a lesson while remaining in a developing state. A learner may also be ready for enrichment or application before achieving fluency.

This chapter exists to prevent those distinctions from being collapsed into a single progress percentage, level, score, or completion marker.

2. Constitutional Authority

This chapter operationalizes the following constitutional commitments:

- 1 mastery **MUST** be scoped and supported by evidence;
- 2 completion **MUST NOT** be treated as mastery;
- 3 progression **SHOULD** be based on demonstrated readiness rather than content consumption;
- 4 required prerequisites **MUST** be sufficiently stable for the demands placed upon them;
- 5 review and remediation **MUST** be normal parts of progression;
- 6 learner momentum **MUST NOT** be preserved by hiding prerequisite failure;
- 7 progression **MUST** develop increasing musical independence;
- 8 old evidence **MAY** require revalidation when current readiness is uncertain;
- 9 learner-facing claims **MUST** not exceed the available evidence; and
- 10 the system **MUST** distinguish inability, insufficient evidence, temporary lapse, and inaccessible task conditions.

Where a curriculum pathway, feature, or assessment uses mastery or progression terminology inconsistently with this chapter, this chapter governs unless a later constitutional amendment explicitly supersedes it.

3. Governing Principle

FretGarden **MUST** advance learners according to the capabilities required for meaningful future learning, not according to the quantity of content they have consumed.

The governing sequence is:

- 1 define the future learning demand;
- 2 identify the capabilities that demand requires;
- 3 classify each prerequisite by importance;
- 4 specify the evidence level required for readiness;
- 5 evaluate current evidence and its confidence;
- 6 distinguish missing evidence from negative evidence;
- 7 determine whether to advance, advance with support, review, remediate, or defer;
- 8 preserve learner agency where multiple valid paths exist;
- 9 record the limits of the decision; and
- 10 revalidate critical capabilities when evidence becomes stale or contradictory.

Progression decisions **MUST** be explainable in educational terms. They **MUST NOT** depend only on a hidden score, arbitrary content order, elapsed time, streak length, or commercial engagement objective.

4. Core Distinctions

4.1 Mastery Is Not Completion

Completion records that an activity or lesson has reached its endpoint. It does not establish retention, transfer, independence, stability, or future readiness.

A learner **MAY** complete a lesson while the objective remains introduced, guided, reconstructed, or developing. Completion and capability status **MUST** remain conceptually separate.

4.2 Mastery Is Not Perfection

Mastery does not require flawless performance under every imaginable condition. It requires sufficiently reliable capability for the defined scope and intended future use.

Minor errors may coexist with mastery when they are infrequent, non-systematic, and recoverable without substantial support.

4.3 Mastery Is Not Permanent

Capabilities can decay, become inaccessible, or fail under changed conditions. A prior mastery designation is historical evidence, not a guarantee of current readiness.

4.4 Readiness Is Not Mastery

Readiness is task-relative. A learner may be ready to begin triad construction with stable interval knowledge that is accurate but not yet fluent. Another task may require faster retrieval.

The required evidence level **MUST** be determined by the demands of the next objective.

4.5 Progression Is Not Promotion

Progression is not a reward for compliance. It is an instructional decision about what work is likely to be productive next.

4.6 Difficulty Is Not Advancement

Harder content is not inherently more advanced in educational value. A more complex task may introduce noise without developing the intended capability.

4.7 Review Is Not Regression

Returning to prior material is part of durable learning. Review, reactivation, and remediation **MUST NOT** be framed as punishment or loss of status.

4.8 Choice Is Not Readiness

A learner's interest in a topic may justify exploratory access, but interest alone does not establish readiness for prerequisite-dependent instruction.

4.9 Access Is Not Certification

FretGarden **MAY** permit learners to explore content beyond their verified readiness. Such access **MUST NOT** create a mastery or progression claim unless the required evidence is produced.

5. Definitions

5.1 Mastery

Mastery is the demonstrated ability to perform or apply a defined capability with sufficient accuracy, stability, understanding, retention, transfer, and independence for its intended future use.

5.2 Functional Mastery

Functional mastery is capability that is reliable enough to support a specified dependent objective.

Functional mastery is narrower than comprehensive mastery and **MUST** name the future demand it supports.

5.3 Comprehensive Mastery

Comprehensive mastery is retained, transferable, fluent, and integrated capability across the expected scope of a domain.

Comprehensive mastery is a strong claim and generally requires converging evidence from multiple conditions and sources.

5.4 Readiness

Readiness is the state in which the learner possesses sufficient prerequisite capability, attention, support, and task orientation to engage productively with a defined objective.

5.5 Prerequisite

A prerequisite is a capability whose absence or instability materially impairs learning, performance, interpretation, or safety in a dependent task.

5.6 Dependency

A dependency is the educational relationship by which one objective relies on another.

Dependencies may be conceptual, perceptual, navigational, physical, temporal, representational, or metacognitive.

5.7 Progression

Progression is the movement among educational states, objectives, pathways, or levels based on evidence, readiness, learner goals, and curriculum relationships.

5.8 Advancement

Advancement is a progression decision that introduces or recommends a new dependent demand.

5.9 Consolidation

Consolidation is continued work intended to stabilize, retain, connect, or increase fluency in an already introduced capability.

5.10 Reactivation

Reactivation is brief retrieval and reconstruction of previously learned material that has become less accessible.

5.11 Remediation

Remediation is targeted instruction intended to repair a misconception, missing prerequisite, patterned error, or unstable capability.

5.12 Revalidation

Revalidation is the collection of current evidence to determine whether a previous capability claim remains sufficiently trustworthy for a new decision.

5.13 Lapse

A lapse is a decline in current accessibility or stability relative to prior evidence.

A lapse does not erase prior learning history. It changes the current readiness judgment.

5.14 Bypass

Bypass is permission to omit or shorten instruction because sufficient prior capability has been demonstrated.

Bypass MUST be evidence-based and scoped.

5.15 Branch

A branch is an alternate valid pathway serving different learner goals, contexts, instruments, or applications without implying a universal hierarchy.

6. Mastery Claim Structure

Every formal mastery claim MUST specify:

- 1 the capability;
- 2 the content scope;
- 3 the conditions of performance;
- 4 the permitted support level;
- 5 the relevant quality dimensions;
- 6 the evidence sources;
- 7 the retention interval where relevant;
- 8 the transfer conditions;
- 9 the date or evidence window;
- 10 the confidence of the claim; and
- 11 the future uses for which the capability is considered sufficient.

Unacceptable:

The learner mastered intervals.

Acceptable:

The learner demonstrated functional mastery of constructing and naming major and minor thirds from varied natural-note roots on the sixth, fifth, and fourth strings without a complete diagram, including successful delayed retrieval and near transfer to triad construction.

A mastery claim MUST NOT extend beyond the sampled scope.

7. Dimensions of Mastery

Mastery is multidimensional. A learner may be strong in one dimension and developing in another.

7.1 Accuracy

The learner's responses or performances conform to the intended target.

7.2 Stability

The capability appears reliably across multiple attempts and minor variations.

7.3 Independence

The learner succeeds without direct solution support.

7.4 Retention

The capability remains available after a meaningful delay.

7.5 Transfer

The learner applies the capability under meaningfully different conditions.

7.6 Fluency

The learner accesses or executes the capability efficiently while preserving accuracy and adaptability.

7.7 Conceptual Coherence

The learner's explanations and decisions reflect a correct and connected model.

7.8 Musical Integration

The capability participates effectively in authentic musical activity.

7.9 Self-Correction

The learner detects and repairs minor errors without substantial external direction.

7.10 Practice Independence

The learner can select appropriate methods for maintaining or extending the capability.

A broad mastery designation SHOULD require evidence across several dimensions. A narrow procedural capability MAY require fewer dimensions when the intended future use is limited.

8. Mastery Levels

FretGarden recognizes the following mastery-related states. These states refine, but do not replace, the developmental levels defined in Chapter 2.

8.1 Not Yet Evidenced

No valid evidence currently supports the capability claim.

This state may reflect missing evidence rather than inability.

8.2 Emerging

The learner demonstrates partial or inconsistent capability, usually with significant support or restricted conditions.

8.3 Guided Functional

The learner can perform the capability reliably with defined support.

8.4 Independent Functional

The learner can perform independently under familiar conditions with sufficient quality for limited use.

8.5 Stable Functional

The capability is reproducible across attempts and minor changes, and is sufficiently stable for specified dependent work.

8.6 Retained Functional

The capability remains available after delay and supports the stated dependent use.

8.7 Transferable Mastery

The learner applies the capability across varied contexts while preserving the defining relationship.

8.8 Fluent Mastery

The capability is efficient, stable, retained, and adaptable at the speed or tempo required for its use.

8.9 Integrated Mastery

The learner combines the capability with other domains in musical, analytical, creative, and self-directed work.

These states **MUST** be attached to a defined capability and scope. They **MUST NOT** be used as global descriptions of a learner.

9. Minimum Evidence for Mastery

A mastery claim **MUST** ordinarily include:

- 1 more than one successful observation;
- 2 independent or appropriately low-prompt performance;
- 3 representative sampling of the stated scope;
- 4 evidence after a meaningful delay;
- 5 at least near-transfer evidence;
- 6 acceptable performance across the relevant quality dimensions;
- 7 no unresolved systematic misconception; and
- 8 sufficient confidence for the consequence of the claim.

Comprehensive mastery **SHOULD** additionally include:

- 1 converging evidence from multiple response modes;
- 2 farther transfer or novel integration;
- 3 musical application;
- 4 fluency where required by future use;
- 5 and self-correction or practice independence.

The absence of one dimension **MAY** be acceptable only when that dimension is genuinely irrelevant to the defined objective.

10. Mastery Thresholds

10.1 Thresholds Must Be Objective-Specific

No universal percentage can define mastery across all musical capabilities.

A ninety-percent score may be inadequate for a safety-critical physical habit or core rhythmic prerequisite and unnecessarily strict for an exploratory creative objective.

10.2 Thresholds Must Reflect Consequences

The stronger the consequence of a mastery decision, the stronger the required evidence.

Unlocking optional enrichment may require less confidence than certifying a prerequisite for a complex integrated unit.

10.3 Thresholds Must Include Quality Dimensions

A threshold **MUST NOT** be based only on total correct responses when rhythm, tone, independence, explanation, transfer, or stability are part of the objective.

10.4 Thresholds Must Account for Guessing

Selected-response accuracy **MUST** be interpreted in light of chance success and item design.

10.5 Thresholds Must Account for Attempts

A learner who reaches the threshold after repeated unsupported guessing has not produced equivalent evidence to a learner who responds accurately and deliberately on the first attempt.

10.6 Borderline Evidence

When evidence lies near a threshold, FretGarden **SHOULD** collect additional targeted evidence rather than force an arbitrary binary decision.

11. Readiness Model

Readiness is determined by the interaction of four factors:

- 1 prerequisite capability;
- 2 current accessibility of that capability;
- 3 demands of the target objective; and
- 4 available instructional support.

A learner is ready when the expected challenge remains productive rather than chaotic.

Readiness **MUST** be evaluated for a defined target. A learner is not simply ready or unready in general.

12. Prerequisite Classification

Every dependent objective **MUST** classify relevant prerequisites.

12.1 Required Prerequisite

The target cannot be learned or performed reliably without this capability.

Required prerequisites **MUST** meet the stated readiness threshold before the dependent objective is treated as full instruction.

12.2 Strongly Recommended Prerequisite

The target remains possible without the capability, but difficulty, confusion, or inefficiency is likely to increase substantially.

FretGarden **MAY** allow progression with additional support and explicit monitoring.

12.3 Supporting Prerequisite

The capability improves context, efficiency, or transfer but is not necessary for initial learning.

12.4 Enrichment Relationship

The capability deepens understanding but does not govern readiness.

12.5 Co-Requisite

The capability can be developed alongside the target because the two objectives reinforce one another without producing excessive load.

Co-requisites **MUST** be chosen deliberately. Two unstable capabilities must not be combined merely to reduce lesson count.

13. Types of Dependency

13.1 Conceptual Dependency

The target relies on a prior explanatory model.

Example: triad construction depends on interval structure.

13.2 Retrieval Dependency

The target requires knowledge to be available from memory.

Example: fluent scale-degree work may depend on accessible note or interval relationships.

13.3 Perceptual Dependency

The learner must hear or discriminate a feature before using it meaningfully.

13.4 Fretboard-Navigation Dependency

The learner must orient to specified locations or anchors.

13.5 Physical Dependency

The target requires a movement or coordination capability.

13.6 Temporal Dependency

The target requires stable pulse, subdivision, or synchronization.

13.7 Representational Dependency

The learner must interpret a notation, diagram, symbol, or instruction format.

13.8 Metacognitive Dependency

The learner must regulate tempo, diagnose errors, or structure practice to undertake the work safely and effectively.

Curriculum authors **MUST** identify the type of dependency because different failures require different remediation.

14. Prerequisite Sufficiency

A prerequisite need not always be comprehensively mastered. It must be sufficiently available for the way it will be used.

The prerequisite standard **SHOULD** specify:

- 1 required accuracy;
- 2 required independence;

- 3 acceptable response latency;
- 4 necessary scope;
- 5 retention requirement;
- 6 transfer requirement;
- 7 and permitted support during the dependent lesson.

Example:

A lesson on constructing major triads may require the learner to reconstruct major thirds and perfect fifths accurately with deliberate reasoning. It may not require immediate interval naming across every root.

By contrast, real-time chord-tone improvisation may require faster and more integrated access.

15. Readiness States

15.1 Ready

Current evidence supports productive engagement under the intended conditions.

15.2 Ready With Support

The learner may proceed if specified scaffolds, review, reduced scope, or slower tempo are provided.

15.3 Exploratory Access

The learner may encounter or sample the content, but the activity is not expected to produce the full objective and MUST NOT be represented as mastery instruction.

15.4 Review Recommended

Evidence suggests that brief reactivation will likely restore readiness.

15.5 Remediation Required

A missing capability, misconception, or patterned failure is likely to prevent productive learning until addressed.

15.6 Readiness Uncertain

Evidence is missing, stale, contradictory, or invalid. Additional diagnostic evidence is required.

15.7 Temporarily Inaccessible

The learner may possess the prerequisite, but current physical, attentional, environmental, or technical conditions prevent valid demonstration.

These states MUST be communicated without assigning moral judgment.

16. Readiness Checks

A readiness check is a brief, targeted collection of evidence before a dependent objective.

Readiness checks SHOULD:

- 1 sample only the capabilities necessary for the target;

- 2 minimize unrelated demands;
- 3 distinguish recall from recognition where relevant;
- 4 use support levels consistent with the dependent task;
- 5 identify whether failure reflects lapse, misconception, or missing knowledge;
- 6 remain short enough not to become a redundant full assessment; and
- 7 route the learner to an appropriate next action.

Readiness checks MUST NOT become surprise gates based on content that was never established as a prerequisite.

17. Progression Decisions

A progression decision may result in:

- 1 advance;
- 2 advance with support;
- 3 continue consolidation;
- 4 schedule review;
- 5 reactivate briefly;
- 6 remediate a specific prerequisite;
- 7 reduce scope or difficulty;
- 8 branch to an alternate valid pathway;
- 9 permit exploratory access without a capability claim;
- 10 or collect additional evidence.

The decision MUST be proportional to the evidence and the educational consequence.

18. Progression States

FretGarden SHOULD distinguish at least the following states for an objective:

- 1 unavailable because dependencies are not met;
- 2 available for exploration;
- 3 recommended next;
- 4 introduced;
- 5 developing with support;
- 6 independently developing;
- 7 ready for consolidation;
- 8 functionally mastered;
- 9 retained;
- 10 transferable;

- 11 fluent;
- 12 integrated;
- 13 review due;
- 14 reactivation needed;
- 15 remediation active;
- 16 and revalidation required.

These states MAY be represented differently to learners, but the underlying educational distinctions MUST remain available.

19. Progression Pathways

19.1 Linear Dependencies

Some objectives have a strong ordered dependency and SHOULD be taught sequentially.

19.2 Branching Pathways

Different learner goals may justify different next objectives after a shared foundation.

Branches MUST be described as alternatives, not as inferior or superior tracks unless evidence supports a genuine hierarchy.

19.3 Spiral Progression

Important concepts may recur at increasing depth, scope, and integration.

Revisiting a concept MUST identify what new capability is being added. Repetition without increased purpose is not spiral progression.

19.4 Parallel Development

Distinct domains may develop concurrently when their demands remain manageable.

19.5 Integration Points

Parallel capabilities should periodically be combined in musical tasks.

19.6 Optional Enrichment

Enrichment MAY be available without altering core readiness or mastery records.

20. Learner Choice and Progression

FretGarden values learner agency. Agency does not require pretending that prerequisites are optional when they are not.

Learners SHOULD be allowed to:

- 1 choose among valid branches;
- 2 select musical applications or genres where objectives remain equivalent;
- 3 revisit prior material voluntarily;
- 4 attempt diagnostic bypass;

- 5 explore advanced topics with clear status limits;
- 6 and influence practice priorities.

FretGarden MUST remain honest about the consequences of skipping required foundations.

21. Bypass and Placement

A learner with prior experience SHOULD not be required to repeat instruction unnecessarily.

Bypass MAY be granted when the learner demonstrates sufficient evidence for the relevant objective.

Bypass evidence MUST:

- 1 match the objective's domain;
- 2 include representative scope;
- 3 account for support and guessing;
- 4 verify critical prerequisites;
- 5 and identify any uneven subskills requiring later review.

Bypass is not a claim that the learner has completed prior FretGarden lessons. It is a claim that the learner possesses sufficient capability to omit or shorten them.

22. Advancement With Support

Advancement with support is appropriate when:

- 1 the prerequisite is close to functional sufficiency;
- 2 the target lesson can provide legitimate scaffolding without obscuring the objective;
- 3 failure can be diagnosed;
- 4 the support has a fading plan;
- 5 and proceeding is unlikely to reinforce misconception or uncontrolled execution.

Advancement with support MUST NOT become a routine way to ignore unstable required prerequisites.

23. Consolidation Before Advancement

Consolidation SHOULD be preferred when the learner can perform independently but lacks sufficient stability, retention, or transfer for the next demand.

Consolidation may include:

- 1 varied retrieval;
- 2 reduced prompts;
- 3 delayed review;
- 4 controlled tempo increases;
- 5 near transfer;
- 6 musical application;

7 and self-explanation.

Consolidation is not filler. It converts fragile performance into reliable capability.

24. Review Due States

A capability SHOULD enter a review-due state when:

- 1 the scheduled retention interval has arrived;
- 2 evidence is old relative to the importance of the capability;
- 3 current work depends on it;
- 4 recent performance suggests weakening access;
- 5 or the learner reports uncertainty that is consistent with observed evidence.

Review due does not mean the capability has been lost. It means current evidence is needed or strengthening is educationally appropriate.

25. Lapse and Reactivation

When a previously learned capability becomes less accessible, FretGarden should first determine whether brief reactivation is sufficient.

Reactivation may include:

- 1 a cue followed by independent retrieval;
- 2 one worked example followed by reconstruction;
- 3 a reduced-scope review;
- 4 a slower performance condition;
- 5 or a familiar musical context.

If capability returns quickly and remains stable, the state may be recorded as reactivated rather than remediated.

If the learner repeatedly requires full re-teaching, the issue should be treated as unstable learning or prerequisite weakness.

26. Remediation Triggers

Remediation is required when evidence indicates:

- 1 a systematic misconception;
- 2 repeated failure of a required prerequisite;
- 3 dependence on support that the target cannot provide;
- 4 inability to distinguish relevant musical relationships;
- 5 recurring timing breakdown;
- 6 physical execution that remains uncontrolled or potentially harmful;
- 7 transfer failure that blocks the target;

8 or repeated errors that do not improve through ordinary feedback.

Remediation MUST identify the smallest meaningful capability that requires repair.

27. Regression and Status Changes

FretGarden MUST distinguish between historical achievement and current accessibility.

A learner's prior mastery record SHOULD remain part of the learning history even if the current state changes to review due, reactivation needed, or temporarily not ready.

Status changes MUST NOT be presented as punishment, lost rank, or personal failure.

A current mastery status MAY be reduced when:

- 1 repeated valid evidence contradicts the prior claim;
- 2 the scope of the original claim was overstated;
- 3 the learner can no longer perform under required conditions;
- 4 or a later correction reveals that the earlier assessment was invalid.

28. Evidence Recency

The acceptable age of evidence depends on:

- 1 the importance of the capability;
- 2 frequency of expected use;
- 3 prior stability;
- 4 degree of integration;
- 5 known forgetting risk;
- 6 and consequence of the progression decision.

No universal expiration period applies to all objectives.

Critical prerequisites SHOULD be sampled again near the point of use when evidence is old or uncertain.

29. Revalidation

Revalidation SHOULD be required when:

- 1 a critical prerequisite has not been used for a substantial period;
- 2 prior evidence was weak or highly prompted;
- 3 current performance conflicts with the mastery record;
- 4 the learner enters a substantially harder context;
- 5 tuning, instrument, representation, or task conditions change materially;
- 6 or a high-consequence claim depends on the capability.

Revalidation SHOULD be focused and minimally burdensome. It is not necessarily a complete reassessment.

30. Confidence and Progression

Progression decisions must consider both estimated capability and confidence in that estimate.

Examples:

- 1 high capability, high confidence: advance or branch normally;
- 2 high capability, low confidence: collect brief additional evidence;
- 3 developing capability, high confidence: consolidate or remediate specifically;
- 4 low apparent capability, low confidence: diagnose before restricting progression.

Uncertainty **MUST NOT** be disguised as failure.

31. Contradictory Evidence

When evidence conflicts, FretGarden **MUST** preserve the dimensions of the conflict.

Examples include:

- 1 accurate recognition but failed recall;
- 2 strong explanation but unstable execution;
- 3 fluent shape performance but weak note or interval identification;
- 4 stable isolated work but failed musical application;
- 5 immediate accuracy but failed delayed retrieval;
- 6 or strong slow performance but breakdown at the required tempo.

Progression should be based on the dimension required by the target objective.

32. Cross-Domain Readiness

Integrated musical tasks require readiness across several domains.

A cross-domain readiness decision **MUST** identify:

- 1 which component capabilities are required;
- 2 the minimum evidence level for each;
- 3 which capability is the primary instructional target;
- 4 which secondary capabilities may remain supported;
- 5 and how failure will be diagnosed.

A single aggregate score **MUST NOT** conceal a critical weakness in one required domain.

33. Rhythm as a Progression Requirement

Rhythmic readiness **MUST** be treated as a genuine prerequisite when the target requires performance in time.

Pitch accuracy alone cannot justify advancement to rhythmically dependent work.

Progression standards **SHOULD** distinguish:

- 1 note or pattern knowledge outside time;
- 2 controlled execution with explicit subdivision;
- 3 synchronization with external pulse;
- 4 temporal independence;
- 5 and musical rhythmic application.

34. Fretboard Readiness

Fretboard progression MUST distinguish among:

- 1 diagram recognition;
- 2 supported location;
- 3 independent note or relationship retrieval;
- 4 reconstruction from anchors;
- 5 position connection;
- 6 functional navigation;
- 7 and integrated musical use.

A learner MUST NOT be advanced on the assumption of fretboard fluency merely because a familiar shape can be reproduced.

35. Ear-Training Readiness

Perceptual progression SHOULD move from clear contrasts toward identification, relational hearing, prediction, and integration.

A learner's inability to label a sound MUST be distinguished from inability to perceive the difference.

Readiness checks should separate detection, discrimination, identification, and application.

36. Physical-Technique Readiness

Physical progression must account for control, coordination, tone, tension, timing, repeatability, and learner-specific physical constraints.

A learner SHOULD NOT be progressed to substantially faster or more complex execution when the current movement is unstable or relies on excessive tension.

One universal fingering MUST NOT be used as a readiness gate when multiple valid physical solutions satisfy the musical objective.

37. Metacognitive Readiness

Some advanced or self-directed work requires the learner to regulate practice independently.

Metacognitive prerequisites may include:

- 1 choosing a manageable tempo;
- 2 isolating an error;

- 3 using focused work and breaks;
- 4 recognizing deteriorating attention;
- 5 and deciding when to reduce difficulty.

FretGarden SHOULD increase learner responsibility gradually rather than assume self-regulation appears automatically.

38. Progression Pace

Progression pace should be determined by evidence and learner context, not by a universal calendar.

FretGarden MUST avoid implying that slower progression is inferior when the learner is developing durable capability.

Faster progression is appropriate when prior knowledge or strong evidence supports it. It MUST NOT be created by weakening standards.

39. Progression and Motivation

Progression systems influence learner behavior.

They MUST NOT reward:

- 1 rushing through explanations;
- 2 guessing until correct;
- 3 practicing beyond useful attention;
- 4 avoiding review;
- 5 sacrificing rhythm or tone for speed;
- 6 or selecting only easy tasks to preserve a score.

Motivational representations SHOULD reinforce consistency, correction, retrieval, reflection, and meaningful musical growth.

40. Learner-Facing Status Language

Learner-facing language SHOULD describe current capability and next action without exaggeration.

Permitted examples include:

- 1 introduced;
- 2 practicing with guidance;
- 3 independent in familiar examples;
- 4 becoming stable;
- 5 ready for the next application;
- 6 retained after review;
- 7 applying in new contexts;
- 8 review recommended;

- 9 and reactivation needed.

Language such as mastered, fluent, complete, or ready **MUST** be reserved for evidence that satisfies the relevant standard.

41. Progression Explanations

When progression is deferred or redirected, FretGarden **SHOULD** explain:

- 1 which capability is affecting readiness;
- 2 what evidence produced the decision;
- 3 whether the issue is missing evidence, lapse, or demonstrated weakness;
- 4 what action is recommended;
- 5 and what evidence will permit advancement.

The explanation should remain concise, respectful, and actionable.

42. Progression Contracts

Every prerequisite-dependent objective **SHOULD** have a progression contract specifying:

- 1 target objective;
- 2 required, recommended, supporting, and enrichment prerequisites;
- 3 readiness threshold for each required prerequisite;
- 4 acceptable support during the target lesson;
- 5 advancement-with-support conditions;
- 6 review and remediation routes;
- 7 bypass conditions;
- 8 revalidation rules;
- 9 and the claims permitted after completion.

43. Curriculum Sequencing Rules

Curriculum sequencing **MUST**:

- 1 reflect prerequisite relationships;
- 2 limit simultaneous novelty;
- 3 provide sufficient consolidation before dependent demands;
- 4 revisit core capabilities after delay;
- 5 create transfer and integration opportunities;
- 6 permit valid branching where goals differ;
- 7 avoid long chains built on unverified assumptions;
- 8 and preserve paths for review and remediation.

Sequence order MUST be justified by learning dependencies rather than tradition alone.

44. Progression Anti-Patterns

The following practices are noncompliant or presumptively noncompliant.

44.1 Completion Unlocks Mastery

Finishing a lesson automatically marks the objective mastered.

44.2 One-Score Progression

A single aggregate number determines advancement while hiding domain-specific weakness.

44.3 Permanent Lockout

A learner is indefinitely blocked without a clear explanation, remediation path, or opportunity to provide new evidence.

44.4 Unrestricted Advance Without Status Limits

The learner skips prerequisites and the system later treats advanced activity as evidence of foundational mastery.

44.5 Review as Punishment

Review is imposed or described as a penalty for failure.

44.6 Speed-Gated Advancement

Tempo alone determines progression while accuracy, timing quality, tone, or tension remain unstable.

44.7 False Precision

Readiness is represented with exact numerical certainty unsupported by the evidence.

44.8 Stale Mastery Assumption

Old mastery status is accepted despite current contradictory evidence.

44.9 Hidden Prerequisites

A learner is assessed or blocked by a capability not previously defined as required.

44.10 Linear-Only Curriculum

Every learner is forced through one sequence despite valid evidence, prior experience, or alternate goals.

45. Constitutional Non-Negotiables

- 1 Completion MUST NOT independently establish mastery.
- 2 Every mastery claim MUST be scoped.
- 3 Every progression decision MUST identify the target demand.
- 4 Required prerequisites MUST have defined readiness thresholds.

- 5 Readiness MUST be evaluated relative to a specific objective.
- 6 Missing evidence MUST NOT be treated automatically as negative evidence.
- 7 A single correct attempt MUST NOT establish stable mastery.
- 8 Immediate performance MUST NOT establish retention.
- 9 Prompted success MUST NOT establish independence.
- 10 Recognition MUST NOT establish recall where recall is required.
- 11 Progression MUST NOT be based solely on time, points, streaks, or completion.
- 12 Review and remediation MUST remain available after advancement.
- 13 Learners MUST receive an actionable route when progression is deferred.
- 14 Critical old evidence MUST be revalidated when current readiness is uncertain.
- 15 A mastery record MUST distinguish historical evidence from current accessibility.
- 16 Aggregate scores MUST NOT conceal failure of a required domain.
- 17 Advancement with support MUST include a support-fading plan.
- 18 Bypass MUST be evidence-based.
- 19 Learner-facing status language MUST not exceed the evidence.
- 20 Progression systems MUST reinforce sustainable, accurate, musically meaningful practice.

46. Conformance Tests

A mastery rule conforms only if reviewers can answer:

- 1 What exact capability is being mastered?
- 2 What is the scope?
- 3 What future use justifies the standard?
- 4 Which quality dimensions matter?
- 5 What evidence sources are required?
- 6 Was performance independent?
- 7 Was it stable across attempts?
- 8 Was it retained after delay?
- 9 Was transfer demonstrated?
- 10 How was guessing controlled?
- 11 What evidence confidence supports the claim?
- 12 When must the capability be revalidated?

A readiness rule conforms only if reviewers can answer:

- 1 What target objective is being considered?
- 2 Which prerequisites are required?
- 3 What type of dependency exists?

- 4 What evidence level is sufficient for each prerequisite?
- 5 Is the evidence current and valid?
- 6 What support may be provided?
- 7 Can the learner proceed productively?
- 8 What happens if readiness is uncertain?
- 9 What review or remediation route exists?
- 10 How will the decision be explained?

A progression rule conforms only if reviewers can answer:

- 1 Why is this the appropriate next demand?
- 2 Is the decision based on capability rather than consumption?
- 3 Are alternate valid branches available?
- 4 Does the sequence limit simultaneous novelty?
- 5 Are consolidation and review obligations defined?
- 6 Can prior knowledge support bypass?
- 7 Can stale evidence be revalidated?
- 8 Does the system preserve learner agency?
- 9 Does it avoid harmful incentives?
- 10 What claims may be made after the learner completes the next work?

47. Tradeoffs and Resolution Rules

47.1 Mastery Versus Momentum

Weak mastery standards preserve short-term movement but create later instability. Excessively broad mastery requirements may delay productive exploration.

The resolution is scoped functional mastery for specific future demands, combined with continued review and later comprehensive development.

47.2 Standardization Versus Individual Pace

Standards must remain consistent while time to reach them may vary.

FretGarden standardizes capability claims, not the number of days or attempts required.

47.3 Learner Choice Versus Prerequisites

Learner agency matters, but required dependencies cannot be made optional by preference.

The resolution is to permit exploration and valid branching while maintaining honest status limits.

47.4 Efficiency Versus Evidence Strength

Frequent full assessments would interrupt learning. Weak checks create false readiness.

The resolution is proportionate evidence: brief readiness sampling for ordinary decisions and stronger converging evidence for consequential mastery claims.

47.5 Stability Versus Challenge

Remaining indefinitely in familiar work limits growth. Advancing before stability creates overload.

The resolution is to advance when prerequisites are functionally sufficient, then continue consolidation through varied and integrated work.

47.6 Historical Achievement Versus Current Capability

Removing all record of prior mastery misrepresents the learner's history. Treating old evidence as permanently current misrepresents readiness.

The resolution is to preserve historical evidence while updating current status.

47.7 Linear Coherence Versus Branching

A coherent curriculum requires dependencies. Different musical goals require choice.

The resolution is a shared foundational structure with evidence-based branches and explicit integration points.

48. Assumptions Made

This chapter assumes:

- 1 FretGarden can distinguish lesson completion from capability status;
- 2 objectives and evidence are defined according to Chapter 2;
- 3 lessons and exercises can produce interpretable evidence;
- 4 assessments can report dimensions rather than only aggregate scores;
- 5 prerequisites can be classified and documented;
- 6 review and remediation routes can be attached to objectives;
- 7 learners may enter with prior knowledge;
- 8 progression may include branching and exploratory access;
- 9 mastery evidence can become stale;
- 10 and later chapters will define detailed review schedules, feedback, remediation, and adaptive sequencing.

49. Unresolved Questions

The following matters remain unresolved:

- 1 standard learner-facing labels for mastery and readiness states;
- 2 task-specific quantitative thresholds;
- 3 default evidence-expiration periods;
- 4 minimum transfer requirements by objective domain;
- 5 when comprehensive mastery should be required rather than functional mastery;
- 6 how many prerequisites may be active in one progression decision;
- 7 default rules for advancement with support;

- 8 criteria for automatic versus author-reviewed bypass;
- 9 treatment of self-directed learners who repeatedly choose exploratory access;
- 10 accessibility-specific readiness demonstrations;
- 11 confidence-calculation methods;
- 12 portability of mastery evidence across tunings and instruments;
- 13 and governance for changing prerequisite graphs after content release.

50. Topics Intentionally Deferred

Deferred topics include:

- 1 review scheduling and spaced retrieval;
- 2 feedback taxonomy and wording;
- 3 detailed error classification;
- 4 remediation architecture;
- 5 adaptive difficulty algorithms;
- 6 prerequisite-graph representation;
- 7 placement-assessment construction;
- 8 learner-facing progress visualization;
- 9 educational analytics;
- 10 confidence aggregation;
- 11 accessibility accommodations;
- 12 curriculum-pathway governance;
- 13 domain-specific mastery rubrics;
- 14 automated-evaluation limits;
- 15 and constitutional change management.

51. Required Future Cross-References

51.1 Review, Retention, and Spaced Retrieval Chapter

Must reference evidence recency, review-due states, lapse, reactivation, revalidation, and retained mastery.

51.2 Feedback and Error Classification Chapter

Must reference contradictory evidence, readiness explanations, error-sensitive progression, and learner-facing status language.

51.3 Remediation and Adaptive Difficulty Chapter

Must reference remediation triggers, advancement with support, prerequisite sufficiency, and progression decisions.

51.4 Curriculum Sequencing Chapter

Must reference prerequisite classification, dependency types, progression pathways, branching, integration points, and progression contracts.

51.5 Placement and Bypass Chapter

Must reference bypass evidence, readiness checks, representative sampling, and prior-learning recognition.

51.6 Domain-Specific Pedagogy Chapters

Must define functional mastery and readiness requirements for their respective objectives without weakening this chapter's evidence obligations.

52. Chapter Conformance Statement

A FretGarden mastery claim conforms to this chapter only when it is scoped, evidence-based, multidimensional, time-aware, and appropriate to the capability's intended future use.

A FretGarden readiness decision conforms only when it identifies the target demand, classifies its prerequisites, evaluates current and relevant evidence, distinguishes uncertainty from demonstrated weakness, and provides a productive next action.

A FretGarden progression rule conforms only when it advances learning rather than content consumption, preserves honest capability states, supports review and remediation, permits justified bypass and branching, and avoids incentives that reward guessing, rushing, or superficial completion.

Progress is not the number of lessons passed. It is the increasing availability, reliability, transfer, integration, and independence of musical capability.

End of Chapter 6 - Mastery, Readiness, and Progression